



Purple patch: Sanju Samson is only the third batter with fifties in both semifinal and final of a men's T20 World Cup, following Shahid Afridi in 2009 and Virat Kohli in 2014.

EMMANUAL YOGINI

dots. One could feel the nervous energy shift inside the press box. But he waited and waited a bit more. The bowler was bound to make an error eventually, as all his coaches would have told him his entire life. And then it came, almost like an announcement — a premeditated move forward to meet the length ball with the meat of the bat. A resounding crack followed as a missile was launched down the ground. Skipper Suryakumar Yadav's post-match thoughts on Samson after the Windies game found relevance once again. "Good things happen to good people who wait,

who have a lot of patience."

Samson had been here two years ago. On the big stage of the T20 World Cup, yet relegated to the bench. He was supposed to play in the big final against South Africa, but 10 minutes before the toss, the team plan changed again, and Samson ended up without a game. He clapped as Rohit Sharma did the Ric Flair walk and lifted the trophy, smiled for the cameras, and returned home.

Once Samson knew what it felt like to be on top of the world, he wanted to relive the feeling, albeit this time as an indispensable member of the eleven. So, back home, he began to bury himself in preparations. **A promotion as an opener triggered a purple patch, as Samson smashed three T20I hundreds in the matter of two months in 2024.**

The momentum, however, did not

last. In 2025, things took a turn for the worse. The Kerala wicketkeeper-batter managed to get only one score in excess of 50 in 15 games. Incidentally, the said half-century not only came against minnow Oman in the Asia Cup but was also scored at a languid pace, off 45 balls in 79 minutes.

At the turn of the next T20 World Cup year, trolls reared their ugly heads once again as Samson registered scores of 10, 6, 0, 24, and 6 during a New Zealand home series. They called him finished, but the 31-year-old knew he had a job to do.

"I've kept on doubting myself, kept on thinking, 'What if (I don't make it)? Can I make it?' Thanks to the Lord Almighty for actually blessing me today. I'm very happy," an emotional Samson would say after the West Indies fixture, his third of this World Cup. Samson has had a marked